

AFP Legislation Compliance Analysis: Barbie (2023)

TLDR

The Barbie movie script presents numerous compliance issues with the Australian Federal Police Act 1979, primarily involving unlawful arrests, theft, impersonation, and the Mattel executives' attempts to unlawfully detain Barbie without proper legal authority. Ken's attempted establishment of a patriarchal constitutional regime in Barbie Land raises serious concerns about obstruction of lawful governance structures, while multiple characters engage in conduct that would constitute AFP conduct issues under Part V of the Act.

Full Analysis

Preliminary Note

It should be acknowledged upfront that the AFP Act governs the Australian Federal Police and its appointees — meaning it applies directly only to AFP members and employees. However, this analysis examines how the characters' conduct intersects with the legislative framework, including offences that AFP members would be obligated to respond to, and how AFP-adjacent conduct (arrests, use of force, detention, impersonation) maps against the Act's provisions.

Character-by-Character Analysis

1. The Mattel CEO and Mattel Executives

Compliance Issues:

The Mattel CEO and his executives orchestrate what amounts to an unlawful detention and attempted false imprisonment of Barbie. When they deploy "Mattel Agents" (described as CIA/FBI-looking types emblazoned with the Mattel logo) to apprehend Barbie outside the junior high school, and subsequently attempt to restrain her in a "human-size Barbie box" using plastic restraining straps, this conduct raises serious concerns.

Relevant Legislation:

Under **Section 14A** of the AFP Act, arrest without warrant is only permissible where a

protective service officer believes on reasonable grounds that a person has just committed or is committing a protective service offence, and that arrest is necessary for specific enumerated purposes (ensuring court appearance, preventing continuation of offence, preventing destruction of evidence, or preserving safety/welfare). The Mattel executives had no such authority — they are not AFP appointees, protective service officers, or members.

Under **Section 14B**, even lawful arresting officers must not use more force or subject a person to greater indignity than is reasonable and necessary. The use of plastic restraining straps in a box clearly fails this standard.

Under **Section 14C**, an arrested person must be informed of the grounds of arrest. The Mattel CEO's explanation ("get into this giant box") does not constitute adequate grounds.

Under **Section 14E**, an arrested person must be delivered into the custody of a police officer as soon as practicable. The Mattel executives had no intention of doing this — their goal was to return Barbie to Barbie Land, bypassing any lawful process entirely.

The attempted detention also potentially engages **Section 40YA** (victimisation) in spirit, as Barbie is being threatened with confinement for conduct (existing in the real world) that she had no control over.

How They Could Have Acted Differently:

Rather than deploying quasi-law-enforcement agents to apprehend Barbie, the Mattel CEO should have:

- Contacted actual AFP or local law enforcement and reported the situation through proper channels
- Sought legal advice about their obligations
- Attempted to communicate voluntarily with Barbie rather than coercively detaining her
- If genuinely concerned about public safety, engaged with authorities under proper legislative frameworks

Score: 1/10

The Mattel executives demonstrated almost complete disregard for lawful arrest procedures, proper use of force standards, and the rights of the individual. The only reason this is not a zero is that they did eventually release Barbie when she escaped, rather than pursuing more extreme measures.

2. Barbie Margot

Compliance Issues:

Barbie is involved in two separate incidents of shoplifting (theft of clothing from a Venice Beach storefront), and assaults a beach-goer who slaps her on the posterior. She is arrested twice during the film.

Relevant Legislation:

The assault is relevant under **Section 64** of the AFP Act, which references offences under sections 147.1 and 149.1 of the Criminal Code (assault and obstruction of officials). While Barbie's assault was on a civilian rather than an AFP member, the conduct itself would constitute a criminal offence that AFP members would be obligated to respond to. The script confirms this — she is arrested for it.

The theft of clothing engages general criminal law that AFP members enforce under **Section 8(1)(b)** of the Act (provision of police services in relation to laws of the Commonwealth and the safeguarding of Commonwealth interests, as well as State offences with a federal aspect under **Section 4AA**).

Barbie's subsequent flight from Mattel headquarters, while sympathetic given the unlawful nature of the attempted detention, involved evading what she believed to be authority figures — though notably she was correct that the detention was unlawful, which would provide a defence.

How She Could Have Acted Differently:

- Regarding the assault: While the provocation was real and understandable, Barbie could have reported the assault to law enforcement rather than retaliating physically. Under the Act's framework, AFP members are obligated to investigate such complaints properly.
- Regarding the theft: Barbie should have sought assistance to obtain clothing through lawful means, or accepted help from Gloria and Sasha rather than taking items without payment.
- Regarding the Mattel detention: Barbie was correct to resist what was effectively an unlawful detention. Her escape was legally justified, though she could have subsequently reported the conduct of the Mattel executives to proper authorities.

Score: 4/10

Barbie's conduct reflects genuine ignorance of legal norms rather than deliberate wrongdoing, and her resistance to unlawful detention was justified. However, the assault and theft are clear breaches that reduce her score significantly.

3. Ken Ryan Gosling

Compliance Issues:

Ken's conduct in the latter half of the film is the most legally problematic of any character. His actions in Barbie Land involve:

1. **Unlawful seizure of property** — taking over Barbie's Dreamhouse without consent
2. **Orchestrating a constitutional coup** — attempting to change the governing constitution of Barbie Land through a manipulated election process
3. **Brainwashing/coercing other Barbies** — inducing psychological manipulation of the Barbies to abandon their autonomy
4. **Incitement** — rallying Kens to "go to war" against other Kens
5. **Theft of Barbie's personal property** — throwing her belongings from the house

Relevant Legislation:

Ken's attempted constitutional coup most directly engages the AFP Act's provisions around **Section 8(1)(b)(iii)** — the safeguarding of Commonwealth interests — and by analogy, the protection of legitimate governance structures. The AFP's function includes protecting democratic institutions.

Ken's seizure of Barbie's property and his coercive conduct toward the Barbies engages the criminal law enforcement functions of the AFP under **Section 8(1)(b)(i)**.

The "beach-off" threats and the organised "war" between Ken factions could constitute incitement to violence, which AFP members are obligated to prevent and investigate.

Ken's conduct in the Real World — attempting to obtain employment as a doctor without qualifications and demanding professional roles based solely on gender — while comedic, reflects conduct that would engage anti-discrimination frameworks that the AFP is obligated to uphold.

How He Could Have Acted Differently:

- Ken's legitimate grievances about his role and identity in Barbie Land could have been raised through proper channels — a petition to President Barbie Issa, for example, or through the Supreme Court
- Rather than orchestrating a coup, Ken could have advocated for constitutional reform through democratic means
- The property seizure should not have occurred — Ken had no legal basis to occupy Barbie's Dreamhouse
- The psychological manipulation of the Barbies constitutes a form of coercive control that has no lawful justification

Score: 1.5/10

Ken's conduct is arguably the most systematically harmful in the film, involving property

seizure, coercive control, incitement, and attempted constitutional subversion. The slight improvement over a zero score reflects that he ultimately recognised the wrongfulness of his conduct, wept appropriately, and voluntarily stepped back from the coup — demonstrating some capacity for self-correction.

4. Gloria

Compliance Issues:

Gloria's conduct raises several issues:

1. **Dangerous driving** — Gloria's car chase through Barbie Land and the Real World involves conduct that would constitute dangerous driving, endangering Sasha (a minor), Barbie, and other road users
2. **Facilitating Barbie's escape from Mattel** — while the detention was unlawful, Gloria's assistance in evading the Mattel agents could constitute obstruction in a more complex legal analysis
3. **Taking Barbie to Barbie Land** — Gloria knowingly transported what she understood to be a living doll across dimensional boundaries, with unpredictable consequences

Relevant Legislation:

The dangerous driving engages the AFP's road policing functions under **Section 8(1)(a)** and **(b)** — the provision of police services in relation to laws of the Commonwealth and the Australian Capital Territory, including traffic enforcement.

Gloria's assistance to Barbie in escaping the Mattel building, however, is more defensibly lawful — she had reasonable grounds to believe that the detention was unlawful (she had overheard the Mattel executives' plans), and assisting a person to escape unlawful detention is not itself unlawful.

Her drawings of "Crippling Shame Barbie," "Irrepressible Thoughts of Death Barbie," and "Full Body Cellulite Barbie" — while not illegal — did cause direct harm to Barbie's wellbeing and contributed to the dimensional rift. This raises interesting questions about duty of care, though no specific AFP provision directly addresses inter-dimensional doll welfare.

How She Could Have Acted Differently:

- Gloria should have driven more carefully, particularly with a minor in the vehicle
- She could have reported the Mattel executives' conduct to proper authorities rather than engaging in a car chase
- Her drawings, while emotionally authentic, should perhaps have been accompanied by

some awareness of their potential consequences — though this is admittedly difficult to anticipate

Score: 5/10

Gloria's motivations are sympathetic and her ultimate actions — deprogramming the Barbies and delivering the speech about the impossibility of being a woman — are genuinely positive contributions. However, the dangerous driving and facilitation of dimensional boundary crossing reduce her score.

5. Sasha

Compliance Issues:

Sasha's primary legal concern is driving a vehicle without a licence. She explicitly acknowledges she does not have a driver's licence when she gets behind the wheel of Barbie's car. She also participates in the broader conspiracy to manipulate the Kens through psychological deception.

Relevant Legislation:

Unlicensed driving engages the AFP's traffic enforcement functions. Under **Section 8(1)(a)**, the AFP provides police services in relation to laws of the Australian Capital Territory, and by extension the Real World jurisdiction in which Sasha drives.

The psychological manipulation of the Kens — while morally complex — was undertaken to restore a legitimate governance structure that had been unlawfully seized. This provides a strong justification defence, though the deceptive means employed remain ethically questionable.

How She Could Have Acted Differently:

- Sasha should not have driven without a licence, particularly in a vehicle she acknowledged had no engine (raising additional questions about roadworthiness)
- The manipulation of the Kens, while effective, could potentially have been replaced with direct confrontation and democratic advocacy

Score: 6/10

Sasha is largely a sympathetic character whose conduct is mostly lawful. The unlicensed driving is the primary concern, offset by her positive role in restoring legitimate governance and her emotional growth throughout the film.

6. Allan

Compliance Issues:

Allan's primary legally relevant conduct is his physical assault on multiple Ken construction workers, described as him taking them all on "rather impressively." He also facilitates the escape of Gloria, Sasha, and himself from Barbie Land through what amounts to a violent breakout.

Relevant Legislation:

The assault on the Ken construction workers engages **Section 64** by analogy and the general criminal law enforcement functions of the AFP under **Section 8**. While Allan's motivation was to escape an oppressive regime, the use of physical force against individuals who were (however misguided) performing what they understood to be legitimate enforcement functions raises concerns.

How He Could Have Acted Differently:

- Allan could have sought to negotiate or distract the Kens through non-violent means
- He could have reported the Ken regime's unlawful conduct to proper authorities rather than resorting to physical confrontation

Score: 5.5/10

Allan's conduct is largely sympathetic — he is escaping an oppressive situation and protecting others. The physical assault is the primary concern, but the proportionality and necessity of his response in the circumstances provides significant mitigation. His consistent refusal to participate in the Ken regime's excesses throughout the film also reflects positively on his character.

7. Weird Barbie

Compliance Issues:

Weird Barbie's conduct is primarily advisory — she directs Barbie Margot to travel to the Real World and provides intelligence about the dimensional rift. Her most legally relevant conduct is operating what amounts to an unofficial intelligence and coordination centre from her Weirdhouse, and her use of a modified vehicle (the "Road Warrior" tank constructed from abandoned Barbie cars) that may not meet roadworthiness standards.

Relevant Legislation:

Weird Barbie's coordination role engages the AFP's intelligence functions under **Section 8(1)(bf)** by analogy — she is effectively providing intelligence and operational support for what becomes a restoration of legitimate governance.

Her vehicle raises questions under traffic and vehicle safety laws that the AFP enforces.

However, Weird Barbie's conduct is overwhelmingly positive from a compliance perspective — she provides accurate intelligence, coordinates a lawful resistance movement, and ultimately supports the restoration of democratic governance in Barbie Land.

How She Could Have Acted Differently:

- Weird Barbie could have been more transparent about the full implications of Barbie's journey from the outset, rather than presenting a false "choice" between the high heel and the Birkenstock
- Her vehicle should be registered and roadworthy

Score: 7/10

Weird Barbie is one of the more legally compliant characters in the film. Her deception about the "choice" is a concern, but her overall conduct supports lawful outcomes and she operates with genuine care for Barbie's wellbeing.

8. Ruth Handler (Ghost)

Compliance Issues:

Ruth's primary concern is her status as a ghost operating from an unofficial office on the 17th floor of Mattel headquarters. The Mattel CEO references her "tax evasion issues," which would engage serious criminal law provisions.

Ruth also facilitates Barbie's transformation into a human — an act of extraordinary consequence that was undertaken without any formal legal process, consent framework, or regulatory oversight.

Relevant Legislation:

The tax evasion issues would engage Commonwealth criminal law that the AFP is obligated to investigate under **Section 8(1)(b)(i)**. The AFP has specific functions relating to the investigation of offences against Commonwealth laws, and tax evasion is a serious Commonwealth offence.

Ruth's facilitation of Barbie's transformation, while presented positively, raises questions

about informed consent and the regulatory framework governing dimensional transitions — areas where the AFP Act provides no specific guidance, suggesting a legislative gap that Parliament may wish to address.

How She Could Have Acted Differently:

- Ruth should have resolved her tax issues with the ATO rather than continuing to operate as a ghost
- The transformation of Barbie into a human should have been subject to a more formal consent and information process, though Ruth does make a genuine attempt to ensure Barbie understands the implications

Score: 6.5/10

Ruth's overall conduct is positive and her intentions are clearly good. The tax evasion history and the somewhat informal approach to an irreversible dimensional transformation prevent a higher score.

Summary Scores

Character	Score /10	Primary Issue
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Mattel CEO & Executives	1/10	Unlawful detention, false imprisonment
Ken Ryan Gosling	1.5/10	Constitutional coup, property seizure, coercive control
Barbie Margot	4/10	Assault, theft
Gloria	5/10	Dangerous driving
Allan	5.5/10	Assault of construction workers
Sasha	6/10	Unlicensed driving
Ruth Handler	6.5/10	Historical tax evasion
Weird Barbie	7/10	Misleading consent process, vehicle compliance

Overall Observations

The film presents a world in which formal legal structures are largely absent from Barbie Land, and the Real World legal framework is encountered by the characters as a series of comic obstacles rather than meaningful constraints. The AFP Act's core values — professional standards, accountability, proper use of force, and the protection of individual rights — are honoured more in the breach than the observance.

The most significant systemic issue is the complete absence of any lawful authority figure who properly exercises their powers in accordance with the Act. The police who arrest

Barbie twice are shown as leering and ineffective. The Mattel executives who attempt to detain her do so